

What Changed in 2026

Java Interview Prep — 2026 Edition · Learn & Excel

An intel report — what's different about Java interviews in 2026 vs 12 months ago. Built from candidate reports across Indian tech in the last two quarters. Read this if you've prepped before and want to know what's new, OR if you're seeing this pack for the first time and want context for the rest of the files.

Executive summary — top 5 shifts in the last 12 months

1. **Virtual threads went from preview-curiosity to standard interview topic.** Java 21 made them GA in Sept 2023; by mid-2024 they were appearing in product-co interviews; by Q1 2026 they're a standard senior-backend question. Spring Boot 3.2+ adoption drove this — flipping one config gets you virtual-thread Tomcat. If you can't talk about pinning, structured concurrency, and when virtual threads HURT (CPU-bound work), you're now behind.
 2. **Spring Boot 3 / Jakarta migration questions replaced "what's new in Java 8" boilerplate.** Most candidates are now from Spring Boot 3 codebases; the interview lens shifted accordingly. The classic "explain Spring beans" question now extends to "you upgraded from 2.7 to 3.0 — what broke?"
 3. **Service MNC freshers hiring is down ~30-40%.** Coding rounds at TCS/Infosys/Cognizant got more selective. Cleared cutoff for many in 2024 = no longer enough in 2026. AI productivity claims squeezed the bottom of the pyramid — fewer junior seats, higher bar for the ones that exist.
 4. **Indian product cos pay 1.4-1.8x what they paid in 2023 for proven mid-to-senior backend engineers.** War for talent — especially fintech (Razorpay, Cred), commerce (Swiggy, Meesho), and AI-adjacent companies. Negotiation leverage at this segment is unusually high.
 5. **System design questions are now happening in round 2, not round 4.** Where previously coding + Java fundamentals dominated rounds 1-3 and system design came late, product cos in 2025-26 push design questions much earlier — selecting hard for "can you architect" not just "can you implement."
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Service MNC patterns — what TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Accenture, Cognizant ask in 2026

Round 1 (technical screen) — the bar moved up

- Coding round is now usually 1-2 medium LeetCode-style problems (where it used to be a single easy one)
- HackerRank/CoCubes scores are scrutinized more — many panels filter at 70%+ vs the older 50% bar
- 3-5 Java OOP/Collections questions on the call — same as before, but now with follow-ups (used to be one-shot)

Round 2 (technical depth) — Spring Boot 3 dominates

- Almost every backend interview now starts with "tell me how Spring Boot autoconfiguration works"
- `@Transactional` with isolation/propagation deep-dive — common
- "Walk through what happens when this controller handler runs from HTTP request to DB and back" — newer, increasingly standard
- Microservices design questions appearing in mid-level (previously only senior)

Round 3 (architect / managerial) — newer topics

- Cloud — most service MNC engineers now expected to know one of AWS/Azure/GCP basics (last year: optional)
- CI/CD pipeline familiarity (Jenkins, GitLab, ArgoCD) — common ask
- Observability — Datadog, New Relic, Prometheus mentioned by name

What FRESHERS specifically face in 2026

- The "lottery" rounds (coding cutoff) got harder
- Project explanation questions are deeper — candidates without real projects (only academic work) struggle
- Communication-round screening is more rigorous — typing-only candidates filtered earlier

Indian product company patterns — Razorpay, Cred, Swiggy, Meesho, Zerodha, Groww

What's hot in their 2026 panels

Distributed systems fundamentals — uniformly required at mid-senior level - CAP theorem with realistic trade-offs (PACELC also showing up at top product cos) - "Design a rate limiter" — top-5 most-asked design question across this segment in 2025-26 - "Design a notification system" — second-most-common - Idempotency — how to make a payment API idempotent, retry semantics, deduplication

Concurrency depth, now expected at mid-level - "Explain how ConcurrentHashMap differs from HashMap" — still asked, but follow-up is now "and what changed in Java 8?" (Q11 in your 01 Top 50) - Virtual threads + pinning — appearing across Razorpay, Cred, Swiggy in 2025-26 - "Show me a deadlock scenario and how you'd debug it in production"

Specific tech-stack questions by company segment - **Fintech (Razorpay, Cred, Slice)**: payment idempotency, eventual consistency, double-entry bookkeeping in code, regulatory/audit requirements affecting design - **Commerce (Swiggy, Meesho, Zomato)**: search ranking, cart-abandonment recovery, surge pricing logic, geo-aware routing - **Brokerages (Zerodha, Groww)**: real-time market data, order matching engines, latency-sensitive design (sub-100ms expectations) - **Education (PhysicsWallah, Vedantu, Unacademy, upGrad)**: video CDN, live-class concurrency, content delivery at scale

What's NOT being asked anymore (vs 2023)

- "What is Java's main method?" — gone from anywhere past round 1
- "Difference between Comparable and Comparator" — still asked but now expected to flow into Comparator chaining + Java 8 idioms in 5 seconds
- Pure SQL questions (joins, indexes) — moved to dedicated SQL pack questions; rarely in Java interviews now

Startup patterns — early-stage vs Series B+

Early-stage (seed / Series A, < 50 people, < 15 engineers)

Interview signal sought: can you ship features end-to-end across the stack? Java is often required but they want: - Full-stack mindset — even if backend-only, you need to discuss frontend integration and DB choices - DevOps awareness — you might be the one configuring AWS / setting up CI - Tradeoff sensitivity — early startups want "good enough, fast" not "perfect, slow" - "What would you build first?" (when handed a vague problem) — top-asked pattern

What's NOT asked: deep system design at scale (because they're not at scale), exotic distributed systems theory

Series B+ (50-300 people, post-product-market-fit)

Interviews start to look like product co interviews above. Key differentiators: - More design depth than early-stage but less rigid than Razorpay-scale companies - More "show me your last bug, walk me through how you found it" practical questions - Cloud-native questions (K8s, Helm, EKS/GKE) appearing more often - Open-source contribution signal valued

Specific 2026 startup pattern: AI-adjacent companies

A wave of Indian AI/ML-infrastructure startups (Sarvam, Krutrim, Tessell, Yellow.ai, CoRover, NeevCloud, etc.) is now hiring Java backend engineers for orchestration / API / inference layers. New question patterns: - "How would you build a request queue in front of a GPU inference service?" - "Explain how you'd implement streaming responses over HTTP with WebFlux" - "Design a vector database query layer" - Interviewers are asking about OpenAI/Anthropic API patterns + LangChain (any language) — showing up on resumes that get callbacks

Java 17/21 — 20 new questions that didn't exist 18 months ago

Listed in rough order of how often they're appearing in interviews now:

1. **"Walk me through virtual threads — how do they differ from platform threads?"** (Razorpay, Cred, Swiggy, Meesho — almost universal at backend senior)
2. **"What does 'pinning' mean for virtual threads, and when does it happen?"** (Razorpay, Cred — usually as follow-up to #1)
3. **"How would you migrate a Tomcat-thread-pool app to virtual threads?"** (Spring-shop interviews — Cred, BharatPe)
4. **"Explain structured concurrency — what problem does it solve over `CompletableFuture` chains?"** (Preview-aware interviewers; uncommon but high-signal when asked)
5. **"What's a record? When NOT to use one?"** (mid-level everywhere — common since 2023, now standard)
6. **"Pattern matching for switch — walk me through how this works with sealed types"** (senior product co interviews)
7. **"Sealed classes — design a small hierarchy using them"** (Cred, Razorpay senior backend)
8. **"What's the difference between Java 17 and Java 21 from a developer's perspective?"** (general, especially at companies on the upgrade path)
9. **"What are sequenced collections? Why were they added in 21?"** (Java-21-aware shops)
10. **"How does Spring Boot 3 use virtual threads?"** (Spring-heavy interviews — Cred, Razorpay, fintech)
11. **"What's `ScopedValue` and when is it better than `ThreadLocal`?"** (preview-aware senior interviews)

12. **"What's the difference between G1 and generational ZGC?"** (performance-engineering rounds)
 13. **"Java 21 removed something — what?"** (trick question; trying to test you know finalize is deprecated-for-removal, not removed)
 14. **"What's a text block? Show me an SQL embed using one"** (basic Java 15+ awareness)
 15. **"How does try-with-resources interact with virtual-thread-per-task executors?"** (subtle but appearing in 2025-26)
 16. **"Spring Boot 3 — what's `jakarta.*` and why?"** (Spring 3 migration awareness)
 17. **"Show me a record with a compact constructor for validation"** (mid-level, common)
 18. **"Switch expressions vs traditional switch statements — when each?"** (mid-level, common)
 19. **"What's `var` ? When does it hurt readability?"** (style/idiom rounds)
 20. **"Project Loom vs Project Reactor — when each?"** (Spring-stack senior rounds)
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Spring Boot 3 + Spring 6 shifts

Spring Boot 3 went GA in Nov 2022, Spring Boot 3.2 (Nov 2023) added virtual thread support, Spring Boot 3.3+ is mainstream. Interviews now assume you're on 3.x.

Specific Spring Boot 3 questions appearing

- **"You're upgrading from Spring Boot 2.7 to 3.0 — what breaks?"** (Service MNC and product co — top-asked Spring upgrade question)
- **"How do you enable virtual threads in Spring Boot 3.2+?"** (one config flag — `spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true` — but interviewer wants you to explain what it does)
- **"What's new about Spring Security 6 vs 5?"** (DSL changed from fluent builder to lambda style — common pitfall during migration)
- **"How does Spring's AOT processing work for native compilation?"** (architect-track rounds)
- **"What's Spring Native / GraalVM? When would you use it?"** (startup interviews where cold-start matters — serverless deployments)
- **"What replaced Spring Sleuth in Spring Boot 3?"** (Micrometer Tracing + Observation API — common follow-up if interviewer cares about observability)

Java 21 + Spring Boot intersection

- "Virtual threads + `synchronized` cause pinning — what's the Spring-idiomatic fix?" (use `ReentrantLock`)
- "How do you observe virtual-thread behavior in production?" (Micrometer counters for thread states; `jcmd Thread.dump_to_file`)

What's falling out of fashion

Spending interview prep time on these in 2026 is wasted effort:

- **XML configuration in Spring** — almost everyone is annotation/Java-config. XML examples used to be common; now you might be asked "have you seen XML config?" and that's it
- **Struts framework** — gone
- **JSF (JavaServer Faces)** — gone for Java backend interviews; relevant only at very specific legacy GCC banks
- **EJB internals** — relevant only at companies maintaining EJB legacy, which is shrinking
- **Servlet API deep-dive** — sub-asked; Spring MVC and reactive abstractions dominate
- **JSP** — same, replaced by REST APIs returning JSON/template-engine variants
- **Hibernate caching strategies (L1 vs L2)** — used to be a senior interview staple; now mostly asked at companies running heavy ORM workloads
- **Java 8 streams basics** — assumed knowledge, not asked separately. "Explain the stream API" is now insulting to a candidate with 3+ years experience.
- **CMS / Concurrent Mark-Sweep GC** — REMOVED in Java 14. Don't waste time learning it.
- **Java's `Vector` class** — only asked as a trick question to see if you know it's legacy

Q1 vs Q3 2026 drift — what's new in the last 90 days

A snapshot of what's appearing right now:

Q3 2026 hot list

- **Stable values (JEP 502, Java 25 preview)** — appearing at companies aware of Java's roadmap, asking "how would you do lazy thread-safe init?"
- **Foreign Function & Memory API (final in Java 22)** — niche but appearing at performance-heavy interviews where JNI alternatives matter
- **Sequenced collections** — gradually replacing the older "how would you reverse a list" patterns
- **GenAI integration questions** — "how would you call Anthropic's API from a Spring Boot service?" — increasingly common
- **Spring AI** — early adopters asking about it; very niche, but rising

Q3 2026 fading

- **Lombok dependency questions** — fewer asks ("do you use Lombok?" used to be common; now records replace much of it)
 - **Maven vs Gradle preference** — debate is more settled (Gradle in product cos, Maven in service MNCs); less interview time spent on it
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What to do with this intel

If you used this pack 12 months ago and are re-prepping now: - Re-read your [01 Top 50](#) Section E (Java 17/21 hot topics) — 5 of those 10 Qs are NEW vs your last prep - Skim Section "Spring Boot 3 questions appearing" above — these are your gap-fill list - Update your "favourite Java feature" answer (Q50 in [01 Top 50](#)) — if your answer is still "lambdas," refresh

If this is your first prep: - Don't get overwhelmed by the modern Java content here. Master the Hot 10 first (Section A of [01 Top 50](#)), THEN come back to the Java 17/21 list. - For your specific target company, focus on the segment patterns above — match your prep to where you're interviewing.

The Java interview landscape moves quarterly. This file gets updated every 6 months.

Go land the offer.

— The Learn & Excel team